

COMMITTEE
MEMBERS'
PAPERS
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Lodge System of
Masonic
Education
Utah, 1961

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THE LODGE SYSTEM OF MASONIC EDUCATION

Prepared by
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Duties, Privileges, and Limitations of An Entered Apprentice

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 1

The limitations under which an Entered Apprentice works are easily described. He cannot belong to a Lodge, vote or hold office; it is only after he has received the Master Mason Degree and signed the By-Laws of his Lodge that he can consummate his membership. And since Masonic Law provides that only members can vote or hold office, he is not yet entitled to these rights. He is not entitled to Masonic burial nor can he walk in public Masonic processions. An Apprentice is not yet a full-fledged Mason; he is still on probation and the Craft has not yet received him as a member. An Apprentice cannot visit or sit in a Lodge except when open on the First Degree. Since all the business of a Lodge is conducted in the Third Degree, this means that he has no voice in its discussion, no vote in its decisions.

Nevertheless, he possesses certain important rights and privileges. He has the right to be coached in this work and to be instructed in matters pertaining to his Degree. If charged with violating his obligation, he is entitled to trial. He has the right to apply for advancement to a higher Degree; this means that he cannot be stopped at his first step through negligence or indifference, or through opposition owing to prejudice. If any member of the Lodge believes that he is unworthy to pass to the Degree of Fellowcraft the question may be decided at a meeting by a majority of the members present at a meeting at which the matter is presented by a committee appointed to investigate the objection. Also, the Apprentice possesses modes of recognition by means of which he can make himself known to other Apprentices and he has the privilege of using them.

Of his duties the chief is to be faithful to his obligation, the clauses of which clearly describe what he is to do and not to do; the obligation is as binding on him as the obligation of the Third Degree is

binding on Master Masons. If, by any chance, he be charged with un-Masonic conduct, the charge will be examined and tried by the Lodge. As an Apprentice you would study it so carefully that both its words and its meaning will remain with you as long as you live.

By the same token it is the duty of the Apprentice to learn the Catechism of the Degree with equal thoroughness because he must prove himself proficient in it in order to make advancement. The lessons thus memorized will remain with him forever. The First Degree is not to be considered a temporary stopping place, to be forgotten when the next Degree is reached; the Degree, rather, is an end in and of itself, perfect and complete within its own field, and its great purpose is that the candidate shall BE an Apprenticed Mason in the sense that its teachings shall become a permanent part of his being.

The Apprentice is on probation, - he is passing through a period of instruction and testing; therefore, it is his duty to be obedient, trusting himself to his guides and quick

to respond to the instructions of the officers of the Lodge in a spirit of humbleness. It is not for him to question what he finds, to discuss the Lodge, or to set himself up as a critic. His presence in the Craft is at yet on sufferance. Nor can he as yet possibly know enough about it to criticize. The clue to his whole position is furnished in the word "Apprentice" itself, which means learner; since he is by status a learner, his chief object is to learn and to learn he must respect his teachers and follow their instructions.

Freemasonry stands in a different case altogether from a golf club or a card club; it preserves a secrecy about all its work; it meets behind tiled doors; it throws over its principles and teachings a garment of symbolism and ritual; its Art is a mystery; a great wall and high separates it from the profane world; it is a \world in itself · standing silently within the great world. Nor is its work so easy to understand as a hand at game of golf, but is often very difficult and is carried forward in the high and responsible regions of the religious, moral, and intellectual life.

For such reasons there is almost nothing in common between it and all those social or entertaining societies which serve as playgrounds for men.

A petitioner who knocks at its portals possesses very slight knowledge of what lies within, brings with him little or no previous preparation; and once he steps inside, he discovers that Masonry lies stretching away before him like a great continent across which he must make long and often difficult journeys in order to reach his goal. The night on which he receives his Master Mason Degree marks, not the end of his journey but only its beginning. The task of learning Masonry, of becoming adept in its work, of fashioning his life according to its requirements, is still before him. In a narrow and technical sense he ceased to be an Apprentice the moment he had taken the Fellowcraft obligation, but in the larger and truer sense he remains an Apprentice until he has mastered Masonic work and is able to take his place in the quarries.

Once he is elected it is not difficult for a candidate to become a member in name and appearance only; but we are sure that your own ambition extends far beyond that perfunctory stage. We believe that you desire to become a Mason in reality and that no idle desire for the honor of bearing the name has been your motive for seeking our fellowship. If this be true, we both urge and advise you not to be content with the letter and outward form only in this, your beginning period, but that rather you will apply yourself with toil, with zeal and with self-sacrifice to the sincere and thorough mastering of our Royal Art.

What Freemasonry Owes to Architecture

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 2

In its earliest period, as you know, our Craft was composed wholly of men engaged in Architecture, or in the practice of some branch of the building arts as a means of livelihood. They had a kind of general Fraternity, and when they gathered at some point to work on a building, a cathedral perhaps, they organized Lodges. We know the Craft of this early period by the name of "Operative Masonry." As time passed Operative Masonry underwent a series of gradual changes until, in the first quarter of the eighteenth century, it became transformed into our present Fraternity of Speculative Freemasonry. But the advent of Speculative Freemasonry did not destroy the old foundation of Operative Masonry; on the contrary, very much of it was preserved and we today are the heirs of many things that have come down to us from our Operative forefathers. I shall now indicate a few of those inheritances.

A large number of our symbols originated in the art of Architecture. You will immediately recall a few of these, for you have already encountered them in the First Degree. But, there are many others. The Working Tools: The Square and Compasses are two of the Great Lights; the cornerstone; the Northeast Corner; the two Ashlars; the Oblong Square; Parallel Lines; each of these arose in the practice of the Operative Masons and there are scores besides. When, therefore, you come to interpret these symbols for yourself, it will be necessary for you to make your start from that fact. Your first questions will be:

What did this tool or this idea mean to the Operative Mason while he was at work on a building? Your next step will be to see that it has the same kind of meaning in all other kinds of work, of building, of constructive endeavor, even in the effort to build character and a

spiritual life. When you have come to all this larger and more general meaning in such a way that you can make use of it in your own daily affairs, you will have grasped the symbolic meaning, for this is just what is meant by symbolism.

Consider, as a special example of this, the Working Tools. It is plain to everybody that in the beginning these were nothing but the tools the Operative Mason used in his work; he had to cut, measure, smooth or carve a stone to make it fit into its proper place in the building structure, and the plumb, square, level, gavel, gauge and trowel were necessarily the tools he had to use. But a stone is not the only thing that has to be measured or shaped, or carved to fit into a place or function. It is also true of a man's mind, of his character. Each man has his own proper place in society; as a worker, as a citizen, as the head of a family, as a neighbor, as a Lodge member. Will he fit into his proper place or will he be a misfit? The question will be decided by how thoroughly and intelligently he uses on himself the methods and influences that are necessary to give shape to his life. Those methods and influences are symbolized by the Working Tools.

By this time, you have learned that Freemasonry is a Fraternity devoted to Brotherhood; to maintain Brotherhood among its own members and to work for it in the world at large is its reason for existence. The erection of a Gothic cathedral called for many workmen; the building was erected according to a plan and this required that each man govern his work accordingly. A group of men thus organized together, all working harmoniously to the same end, constitute a Brotherhood; this Masonic Brotherhood, therefore, instead of being the result of a mere vague aspiration, was a product of the practice of the art of architecture as that art then was.

We do not achieve Brotherhood by a random sentimentality, merely by shaking hands and patting each other on the back, but by our all working together at the same task. Most of the great things in this world must be done, if ever they are to be done at all, by co-operative enterprise, and unless a man is able to co-operate, he cannot have a share in doing them.

We hope that you may learn to detect all our architectural symbols and emblems; that you may study them, reflect and ponder them and seek to learn what they mean for you in your own experience.

Symbols of the First Degree

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 3

The symbols, emblems and allegorical ceremonies of the First Degree have each a meaning and these meanings comprise the teaching of the Degree. We believe that it will be profitable to you to have a few hints and suggestions, as they will show that every detail of the Ritual is filled with a definite significance which each Mason can learn if he applies himself.

The Hoodwink represents the darkness in which an uninitiated man stands as regards the Masonic life; for this reason, it is removed at the moment of enlightenment. Its removal suggests that we do not make the great things of existence but find them; it is our blindness that conceals them from us.

The Cable Tow is a symbol of all those earthly restraints by which a man is controlled by others or by forces outside himself. If a man does not keep the law of his own free will, he must be compelled to keep it by compulsion. The removal of the Cable Tow means that when a man becomes master of himself, he will keep the law instinctively, out of his own character.

The Lodge is a symbol of the world. The symbol means that in its scope and extent Freemasonry is as broad as human nature and as wide as mankind, and that as a spirit and ideal it permeates the whole life of every true Mason, outside the Lodge as well as inside.

The Ceremony of Entrance by which is meant all that happens at the Inner Door, signifies birth or initiation and symbolizes the fact that a candidate is entering the world of Masonry, there to live a new kind of life.

The Sharp Instrument means that which is the one real penalty for violations of the Obligations, the destructive consequences to a man's nature of being faithless to his vows, untrue to his word.

The Rite of Circumambulation is Masonry 's name for the ceremony of walking around the Lodge-room, an allegorical act rich with many meanings. One of the principal of these is that the Masonic life is a progressive journey, from station to station of attainment, and that a Mason will always be in search of more light.

An equally significant ceremony is that of Approaching the East. The East is the source of Light.

The Altar is the most important article of furniture in a Lodge-room- a place at the center around which all else revolves.

The Obligations have in them many literal meanings and as such are the foundations of our disciplinary law but, over and above this, they signify the nature and place of obligation in human life. A righteous man can be depended upon to fulfill his obligations to the best of his ability.

The Rite of Salutation, in which the candidate salutes each station, is a symbol of a Mason's respect for and obedience to all just and duly constituted authorities.

The same significance is had by the office of Worshipful Master who is a symbol as well as the executive officer of the Lodge. As the sun rules the day, he rules and governs his Lodge. His title "Worshipful" means that as the governor he is worthy of reverence, respect and obedience.

The Apron is at once the emblem of purity and badge of a Mason.

In the Rite of Destitution, the candidate discovers that he has nothing of a metallic character on his person. The candidate is not to bring into the Lodge-room his passions or prejudices lest the harmony, which is one of the chief concerns of Masonry to sustain, will be destroyed.

The Northeast Corner is traditionally the place where the cornerstone of a building is laid; when the Apprentice is made to stand there, it is because he is the cornerstone of the future Craft. What the Apprentices are today Masonry will become in the future.

The Working Tools represent those moral and spiritual virtues, habits and forces by means of which a man is enabled to reshape the crude and often stubborn materials of his nature in order to adjust himself to the need and requirements of human society. If a man has lived planlessly, carelessly, without aim or ideal he must, if he is to become a Mason, learn to systematize his life, must adopt a plan as signified by the Twenty-four Inch Gauge. If he has traits of temper, habits of speech or defects of character that disturb or injure others and interfere with his taking his proper place in the Brotherhood, he must rid himself of them. This is represented by the Common Gavel.

The Entered Apprentice is himself a symbol. He represents youth, trained youth, willing to submit itself to discipline and seek knowledge in order to learn the great Art of life, which is the real Royal Art, and which itself is represented and interpreted by all the Mysteries of Masonry.

Place of the Obligations in Masonic Law

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 4

As an Entered Apprentice you have already taken the first of three obligations; the next will make you a Fellowcraft Mason; the third will make you a Master Mason.

If at this stage, you pause to reflect upon the meaning and place of obligations in Masonry, more particularly in the law of Masonry, you will be enabled to assume your next obligations with greater interest and a clearer understanding.

“Obligation” is one of those words which define themselves. The root of it is the same as the root of our word “ligament” and means a cord or tendon by which one thing is tied to another. An obligation, therefore, is a solemn pledge, made on a man’s honor, by which he ties himself to a society and at the same time himself to the duties and responsibilities imposed by it. Such an obligation a man cannot disregard except at the cost of traducing his own honor. The Masonic obligations are taken by the candidate as binding without limit of time; that is, he accepts them for the remainder of his natural life; he may possibly in the future withdraw from the Fraternity or by it be suspended or expelled, but that will not ease him of his pledge because he took that pledge, not as a Lodge member, but as a man. This is the meaning of the old saying: “Once a Mason, always a Mason.”

Upon taking the obligation you became an Entered Apprentice. Your obligation may be divided into “affirmative points” and “negative points”. The positive points consist of those clauses which require certain acts to be done; the negative points are those which forbid that other acts be done. Both the positive and the negative points are covered by one general point requiring that the whole obligation be kept in strictest secrecy; this is called the “Tie.”

No man can take a Masonic obligation that may be considered binding unless he is of lawful age and unless he is of sound mind, not insane nor in his dotage. This means that the candidate taking it accepts, and is competent to accept, full responsibility for it. If afterwards he is charged with having violated any of the points, he cannot seek to evade the consequences by pleading ignorance or inability at the time he gave his pledge. This is all of a piece with Freemasonry's attitude to the candidate throughout; no pressure is brought to bear upon him, no undue influence he comes unsolicited and of his own free will and accord, as a free man in every sense of the word; he is left free to withdraw before taking any obligation; in short, it is ascertained at every step that he is competent and, to that end, he is responsible for every promise he makes and every pledge he gives.

There is among the laws of Masonry a set of laws which regulate an individual's conduct as a Mason; these lay down what is demanded of him in conduct, define Masonic crimes and affix certain penalties. These may be described as the disciplinary laws of the Craft. In the majority of cases brought to trial for un-Masonic conduct it is this disciplinary law that is involved. The important point about our disciplinary law is that the obligations are its foundation. Pay close attention to this fact and for this reason: the obligations appear as a portion of the Ritual; much of that Ritual is symbolical and not to be taken literally, therefore, you may be tempted to feel that the obligations also are merely symbolical and are a kind of formality of ceremony; this is not true, for the obligations are in force in the same manner as all other definite law, are in fact themselves law in its most definite and specific sense. This is important for you to know and to remember in the outset of your Masonic career, because the obligation will always remain binding. Your conduct as a Mason is not left to the guidance of any vague mood or uncertain feeling but is to be governed according to strict and clearly stated rules.

You may wish to know why it is, if this be true, that the penalties attached to the obligations are of a type so different from the obligations proper. If the positive and negative points of the obligations

proper to be taken literally, why not also the penalties? The answer is that the penalties are to be taken as they stand when they are correctly understood. The form of these penalties comes to us from history. Speculative Freemasonry began in England with the organization of the first Grand Lodge in 1717. At that time all crimes were understood to belong to either of two classes, heresy or treason. By heresy was meant some violation of the religious principles, morals and ideals of the State; by treason was meant some crime against the political and legal authority of the State. Two sets of punishments, familiar to everybody for three or four centuries, became so identified with the two types of crime that they became synonymous with them. You can now understand our own penalties; they mean that any crime against Masonry is either heresy-that is, a violation of its teachings; or treason-that is, against the authority of Lodge or Grand Lodge or against our laws. The penalties are a symbolical presentation of that truth, and truth it is because a Mason may be punished for violating the official teachings of Masonry as surely as for violating its written laws.

As for punishments literally in force, they may be, as our Code states: reprimand, suspension from all the rights of Masonry for a definite time, and expulsion. The penalties attached to the obligations express the general nature of the offense; the penalties prescribed in the Trial Code describe the punishments literally in force.

At no point does our Fraternity transgress upon the province of the civil authorities-to do so would violate the Landmarks-but within its own province it is itself a system of law and order. A body of unwritten law is in force within it; the Lodge and Grand Lodge may make and interpret the law; certain Lodge and Grand Lodge officers enforce the law; and both the Lodge and Grand Lodge may sit as courts for the trial of cases, may hear testimony, decide innocence or guilt and affix penalties.

Such facts as these are of paramount importance to you as you form your conception of Freemasonry. Our Craft is not a formless social circle but a completely organized institution in which law, the

enforcement of law, and punishment for crime are as serious and real as they are anywhere outside it. The obligations, as the climax and summit of each of the Degrees, are an expression of this and are a visible embodiment of our system of law and order.

The Mason as a Citizen

Meeting No. 2

Subject No. 5

In the Old Charges it is laid down as a fundamental law of the Craft that "a Mason is a peaceable subject to the Civil Powers, wherever he resides or works, and is never to be concerned in Plots and Conspiracies against the peace and welfare of the Nation ... " The Charge to the Entered Apprentice states: "in the State, you are to be a quiet and peaceful citizen, true to your government and just to your country. You are not to countenance disloyalty or rebellion, but patiently to submit to legal authority, and conform with cheerfulness to the government of the country in which you live."

At the time the Old Charges were written the people had no voice in their government; they were ruled by kings, and often the dynasty to which a king belonged was challenged in its right to rule by some other dynasty; a rebellion or a revolution was the only method by which a government could be changed. Almost every organization, including even churches and colleges, took sides with one dynasty as against the other. Masonic law took the position that this system of warring parties was hurtful to mankind and a great danger to a people, and that it ought to be replaced by the principle of goodwill and peaceable co.-operation.

Here in America we have no king or dynasties, but we continue to have parties. Instead of quarreling with each other as to what the government shall be, our parties are in contention as to what the government shall do; and instead of deciding which one shall triumph by means of rebellions and revolutions, our parties make use of political campaigns, and while these campaigns do not result in the shedding of blood they often result in a great deal of bitterness. In the face of this modern situation our Craft continues to take the same position that it took in an earlier time; it believes that these bitter, partisan contentions are hurtful to the people, subversive of sound government and that the welfare of the State can be best secured by

good-will, toleration and a patient, friendly co-operation. It, therefore, refuses to participate in partisan politics and forbids its members ever to do so in the name of Masonry.

It is now possible for us to define the Masonic conception of citizenship. It means that in all his relations with the community and the State a man is motivated and controlled by the principle of fraternalism, which means that as one of the people, he works for and with the people in the spirit of goodwill and for the general good. He is to apply fraternalism in detail in such manner as meets with his best judgment.

A Mason may be an active worker in some political party: what party it is, is for him to decide; but as a Mason he will not hate those who differ from him, nor enter unjust intrigues against them; he will not set up his own party in opposition to the public good, nor will he proselyte for supporters among his Brethren.

He may be an active member of a church, and as a Mason he will have goodwill toward men of a different faith; he will not be actuated by prejudice or intolerance, nor will he be a party to making war upon any other religious communion however much in error he may deem it to be.

In his social life he may belong to any circle he wishes, wealthy or poor, and enjoy the companionship of such as please him, nobody else having any right to dictate; but as a Mason he will not consider his own circle above others, or despise those who may not be as fortunate as he in his social relations-for such snobbery is repugnant to the principle of fraternalism.

Again, it is possible that he may feel a pride of race, may cherish the traditions of his own people, may love its language and prefer its customs; if so, nobody has the right to forbid him, for it is right and honorable in every man to respect his own blood; but as a Mason he will not, therefore, despise others of a different race, nor seek at their expense to exalt his own; for there is nothing more un-Masonic than race prejudice.

Freemasonry leaves it wholly to us to decide what form our citizenship shall take in detail or where we shall find our own niche in the great structure of public life.

You will now understand why neither a Lodge, nor Grand Lodge nor any group of Masons as such, ever interfere with matters of church, state, or society, or joins one party as against another. It is not inconsistent for the Craft to perform such services to the community as stand by common consent on a level beyond all parties.

Lodges or groups of their members have assisted to raise funds for or to build public libraries. Also, the Craft appears publicly to lay the cornerstone of some public building.

For many generations it has been especially friendly to the public schools, not alone because its own motto is: "Let there be Light," but in order to assist the children of every family in a community to enjoy educational advantages regardless of race, or creed, or party.

To sum up:

If a Mason asks, "How am I to apply the teachings of Masonry to Citizenship?" - the answer is:

That is for you to decide and according as you have opportunity. All that is required of you is to be guided throughout by the principle of fraternalism.

